

The Doll's Levee

Slow air



The Doll's Levee: A sweet little tune by James Scott Skinner which might suit a band looking for a medley piece. It began life as a setting for a poem by Skinner's friend, "Gramin", the schoolmaster of Lumsden in western Aberdeenshire. It envisages a kind of Scottish "Teddy Bears' Picnic". The "Ross" whose skills are rivalled by the teddy bear piper is of course the famous *Uilleam* Ross, the Queen's own first piper.



Uilleam Ross from a contemporary engraving

NURSERY SONGS.

The Dolls' Levee.

(To the Misses SMITH. Lumsden.)

NURSERY SONG.
Written by GRAMIN.

J. SCOTT SKINNER.



Weel may Lumsden loup and caper,
Nane will ferlie at her glee,
Nane will wonder if she drape her
In the robes o' jubilee.
Ring the bells and bang the leather—
Spread the news frae sea to sea!
Queen Victoria, through the heather,
Comes to grace the dolls' levee.

A' the dolls are waitin' ready,
Mim and trim, as dolls should be;
Yonder comes the royal lady,
Ilka dolly crooks her knee.
"Rise, ye crood o' little beauties,
Dinna creenge and kneel to me;
Ere I bore my queenly duties
Danced I at a dolls' levee.

"Noo I've grown an ancient granny,
Stout and portly, as ye see,
Tho', sin' I lost my cantie mannie,
Nae so blithe's I used to be;
But my heart's as young as ever—
Goodness, what I widna gie
That my limbs were half as clever
As they were in '33!

"Dance, ye bonnie smilin' teddies,
Jeffrey, gie your bag a squeeze,
Sune ye'll ha'e them, lads and leddies,
Bizzin' ower the floor like bees.
Alick, mate wi' Annabella,
Hairry, dance wi' fa' ye please,
Jamie, rise ye lazy fellow,
Lollin' there at a' your ease!

"Mary, wi' your broken leggie,
Can ye hirple through a reel?
Good o' you, my cripple Meggie,
Dancin' sets you unco weel!
Ella, Flora, Henrietta,
Ye've been at the dancin' squeel;
Jeffrey, cease your allegretto,
What they want's a hearty dreel.

"Haith, my lad, ye're pipin' rarely—
That's as weel as Ross could dee;
Tennyson ye cappit fairly
When ye sang the 'Jubilee'
I maun shortly noo examine
Which o' a' the gifted three—
You, or Willie La, or Gramin—
Future Laureate shall be.

"Noo, my dears, ye're het and reekin',
Jeannie Souter, lay the tea;
Soon the gait I maun be seekin',
Back again to Bonnie Dee.
Cares o' state in endless measure,
Plague me sair, I winna lee,
But I'll aye reflect wi' pleasure
On the Lumsden Dolls' Levee!"

Ch. M. 18

The Dolls' Levee from Scott Skinner's Logie Collection, published in 1888. The words include reference to leading piper Uilleam Ross (1823-1891) who alternated with Skinner in playing for dancing entertainments at Balmoral Castle